

were organised by arrested SIMI chief Safdar Nagori in four states in the past one year. Around 200 radical Muslim youths participated. If all of them are arrested, most of the key terror cases in the country in the past two years would be solved." The statement was only pointing to the transformation of SIMI to a deadly terror outfit.

The biggest example of SIMI's new-found capability was the Ahmedabad blasts operation, carried out with precision. It involved over 60 SIMI activists, including 35 from Gujarat with the rest providing support from Maharashtra, Karnataka, Madhya Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh and Maharashtra. Around 15 of them have been arrested. The main conspirators in the case were Bashir and Abdus Subhan Qureshi, 27, alias Tauqir, a software expert from Mumbai's Mira Road area, now absconding. He is also a key conspirator in the 2006 Mumbai train blasts (which took nearly 200 lives) and in the Jaipur and Uttar Pradesh court blasts. The two had emerged as Nagori's right-hand men till his arrest with 12 others from Indore in March last. After Nagori's arrest, Bashir became 'jim-mewar' (president) of IM and Tauqir was installed as 'ansar' (general secretary).

Bashir's arrest was carried out with precision. A joint team of Gujarat and Uttar



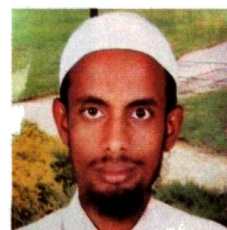
PRIZE CATCH: Crime Branch officials with arrested SIMI cadres

Pradesh police reached his house in Dinapara village of Azamgarh on August 14 pretending to discuss a marriage proposal for his younger brother. The moment Bashir emerged, he was pushed into a waiting Tata Sumo and whisked away. His family registered a case of kidnapping only to be informed that he had been taken away by the police. Azamgarh is not new to criminals—underworld don Abu Salem, convicted in the 1993 Mumbai blasts case, is originally from here. The region is known to be a breeding ground for Mumbai-based

Graphic by SAURABH SINGH and PRASHANT CHAUDHARY

TRAINING CAMPS

The beehive of SIMI's terror campaign are the training camps in Kerala, Gujarat and Karnataka



MASTERMIND
Mufti Abu Bashir, 28, the main accused in the Ahmedabad blasts who studied at the Deoband madrasa, charted the deadly plan and left it to SIMI executioners to carry it ahead.

MOBILE PHONES

Calls made from five other cell phones, which were switched off three hours before the blasts, were tracked.

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MAKING THE BOMBS

Imran told the police how the bombs were assembled in his Vadodara house and that the rest of the bombs were put together in Vatva and Bapunagar areas of Ahmedabad.

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